VENVLEARNING

STUDENT TEXTBOOK

Social Studies

GRADE 7

Lessons, examples, and practice for the whole year

Unit 1: Early Humans and Mesopotamia

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Social Studies

STUDENT TEXTBOOK

Unit 1 Early Humans and Mesopotamia

A VenvLearning family homeschool curriculum

How to use this book

Every lesson starts on a new page with the same parts, so you always know where to look. Read the Look Closer boxes to see how a historian or geographer reads a source, map, or chart, and answer the Check Your Understanding questions. Your practice pages are in your Student Workbook, labeled with the same lesson number.

- Today's Goal (the box with the target) says what you will be able to do by the end of the lesson.
- Today's Assignment is your checklist for the day. Tick each box as you finish it.
- The lesson then goes in numbered steps: 1 Get Ready, 2 Learn, 3 Check Your Understanding, and 4 Wrap Up.
- Boxes with a colored label are lesson information: Words to Know, Key Idea (the most important rule or fact; learn these), worked examples, and Watch Out warnings about common mistakes.
- Pages that look like a page from a book, on cream paper with a brown READING tab, are things to read: stories, excerpts, and articles.
- Activity boxes are hands-on map, source, and timeline work. Do them with your teacher.
- At the end of each week of lessons there is a short Weekly Check in your workbook. Each unit ends with the Unit Test.

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UNIT 1

Early Humans and Mesopotamia

Historians' tools, early humans, the Agricultural Revolution, the first cities, Sumer, writing, and the first empires and laws.

Ten thousand years ago, nearly everyone on Earth lived by hunting and gathering. Then, in a few river valleys, people began to farm, settle, and build cities. In this unit you'll learn how historians uncover the distant past, then follow humans from the Old Stone Age to Sumer, where people built the first cities, invented writing, and carved laws in stone.

In this unit you will...

- Use primary and secondary sources and read BCE/CE timelines.
- Explain how the Agricultural Revolution changed human life.
- Analyze how Mesopotamia's geography shaped civilization.
- Describe Sumerian society, writing, and the first empires and laws.

CONNECTIONS TODAY

Writing, cities, and written law all began in Mesopotamia. Every time you read a contract, check the time, or follow a posted rule, you're using ideas over 4,000 years old.

UNIT VOCABULARY

primary source	Created at the time by a participant.
Agricultural Revolution	The shift to farming.
civilization	A complex society with cities and government.
irrigation	Bringing water to crops.
cuneiform	Sumerian wedge-shaped writing.
empire	Many lands under one ruler.

Lessons in this unit

Lesson	Title
1.1	How Historians Know the Past
1.2	Early Humans: Hunter-Gatherers
1.3	The Agricultural Revolution
1.4	From Villages to Civilizations
1.5	Mesopotamia: The Land Between the Rivers
1.6	Sumer: City-States, Ziggurats, and Society
1.7	Cuneiform and the Invention of Writing
1.8	Empires and the Code of Hammurabi

LESSON 1.1
Week 1 · Lesson 1 of 2
Unit 1: Early Humans and Mesopotamia

Lesson 1.1: How Historians Know the Past

TODAY'S GOAL

I can distinguish primary and secondary sources, explain how archaeologists learn about the past, and read a BCE/CE timeline.

Standards: C3 D2.His.9.6-8, D2.His.10.6-8

TODAY'S ASSIGNMENT

- ☐ Read Lesson 1.1 in this book with your teacher.
- ☐ Do the Activity activity: Time Capsule Detectives.
- ☐ Answer the Check Your Understanding questions in Workbook Lesson 1.1, Part A.
- ☐ Complete the rest of Workbook Lesson 1.1 (Parts B–D).

WORDS TO KNOW

primary source	A source created by someone who was there at the time.
secondary source	A source created later by someone studying the past.
artifact	An object made or used by people in the past.
archaeologist	A scientist who studies the past by digging up and examining artifacts and remains.
BCE / CE	"Before the Common Era" and "Common Era": the years before and after year 1.

1 Get Ready

THINK ABOUT IT

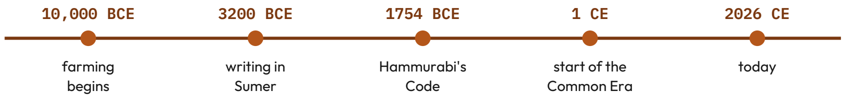
Imagine someone in 5,000 years digs up your bedroom. What would your things tell them about you, and what would they get wrong?

2 Learn

Historians are detectives. They gather evidence from primary sources (letters, laws, inscriptions, photographs, artifacts) and secondary sources (textbooks, articles, documentaries). For times before writing, archaeologists study artifacts, bones, seeds, and buildings. Scientists can estimate the age of once-living material using radiocarbon dating.

Every source has limits. A king's inscription may brag. Artifacts made of stone and clay survive, but cloth, wood, and memories usually don't. Good historians ask: Who made this? When? Why? What might be missing?

Dates before year 1 are written BCE and count down toward year 1: 3000 BCE is earlier than 2000 BCE. Dates after are CE and count up. There is no year 0.



LOOK CLOSER · COUNT ACROSS THE BCE/CE LINE

How many years passed between 500 BCE and 500 CE?

1. From 500 BCE to 1 BCE is 499 years; then 1 BCE to 1 CE is 1 year.
2. From 1 CE to 500 CE is 499 years.
3. 499 + 1 + 499 = 999.

Answer: 999 years (because there is no year 0).

ACTIVITY · TIME CAPSULE DETECTIVES

What can objects tell us, and what can't they?

You need: a box of 6–8 everyday objects chosen by your teacher (receipt, toy, coin, photo, tool, food wrapper).

1. Examine each object as if you were an archaeologist in the year 7026.
2. For each, write one inference about the people who used it.
3. Sort the objects into primary sources and secondary sources (if any).
4. Write what these objects can't tell you about the family.

Record: an evidence chart: Object | What it suggests | Questions it raises.

KEY IDEA

Historians use primary and secondary sources, ask who made a source and why, and recognize that evidence is always incomplete.

3 Check Your Understanding

✎ CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Directions: Write primary or secondary for each source, or answer the question. Write your answers in Workbook Lesson 1.1, Part A. Then check with your teacher.

1. Primary or secondary: a clay tablet written in 2000 BCE
2. Primary or secondary: a website about ancient Sumer
3. Which is earlier, 2500 BCE or 1800 BCE?

4 Wrap Up

✓ REMEMBER

Historians use primary and secondary sources; BCE counts down, CE counts up.

LESSON 1.2
Week 1 · Lesson 2 of 2

Unit 1: Early Humans and Mesopotamia

Lesson 1.2: Early Humans: Hunter-Gatherers

TODAY'S GOAL

I can describe how early humans lived as hunter-gatherers and spread across the world.

Standards: C3 D2.His.1.6-8, D2.Geo.6.6-8

TODAY'S ASSIGNMENT

- ☐ Read Lesson 1.2 in this book with your teacher.
- ☐ Do the Activity activity: What's in the Pack?.
- ☐ Answer the Check Your Understanding questions in Workbook Lesson 1.2, Part A.
- ☐ Complete the rest of Workbook Lesson 1.2 (Parts B–D).

WORDS TO KNOW

hunter-gatherer	A person who gets food by hunting animals and gathering wild plants.
nomad	A person who moves from place to place instead of living in one settlement.
Paleolithic	The Old Stone Age, when people made stone tools and lived as hunter-gatherers.
migration	Movement of people from one place to another.

1 Get Ready

THINK ABOUT IT

If you had no stores, farms, or metal tools, how would you get food and stay warm?

2 Learn

Fossils show that our species, Homo sapiens, appeared in Africa roughly 300,000 years ago. Over many thousands of years, groups migrated out of Africa into Asia, Europe, Australia, and eventually the Americas.

For almost all of human history, people lived as hunter-gatherers during the Paleolithic, or Old Stone Age. Small groups of related families moved with the seasons, following herds and ripening plants. They made tools of stone, bone, and wood, used fire to cook and stay warm, made clothing from hides, and painted animals on cave walls, such as the famous paintings at Lascaux, France, made about 17,000 years ago.

Need	How hunter-gatherers met it
food	hunting, fishing, gathering nuts, roots, berries
shelter	caves, huts of branches, bones, and hides
tools	stone blades and scrapers, spears, needles of bone
communication and art	spoken language, cave paintings, carvings, music

ACTIVITY · WHAT'S IN THE PACK?

What would a nomadic family carry?

You need: paper; pencil.

1 Your band of 25 is moving to its winter camp. Everything must be carried.
2 List the 8 most important items you would take and why.
3 Compare your list with a family member's and agree on a final list.

Record: your final list with a reason for each item.

KEY IDEA

For most of human history, people were nomadic hunter-gatherers who used stone tools and fire and spread from Africa across the world.

3 Check Your Understanding

✎ CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Directions: Answer each question. Write your answers in Workbook Lesson 1.2, Part A. Then check with your teacher.

1. Where did Homo sapiens first appear?
2. Why did hunter-gatherers move often?
3. Name one Paleolithic technology.

4 Wrap Up

✓ REMEMBER

Early humans were nomadic hunter-gatherers who spread out of Africa.

LESSON 1.3
Week 2 · Lesson 1 of 2

Unit 1: Early Humans and Mesopotamia

Lesson 1.3: The Agricultural Revolution

TODAY'S GOAL

I can explain how farming began and how it changed human life.

Standards: C3 D2.His.2.6-8, D2.Geo.4.6-8

TODAY'S ASSIGNMENT

- ☐ Read Lesson 1.3 in this book with your teacher.
- ☐ Do the Activity activity: Gains and Losses.
- ☐ Answer the Check Your Understanding questions in Workbook Lesson 1.3, Part A.
- ☐ Complete the rest of Workbook Lesson 1.3 (Parts B–D).

WORDS TO KNOW

domestication	Taming plants and animals so they can be raised by people.
Neolithic	The New Stone Age, when farming began.
surplus	More than is needed to survive.
Agricultural Revolution	The shift from hunting and gathering to farming.

1 Get Ready

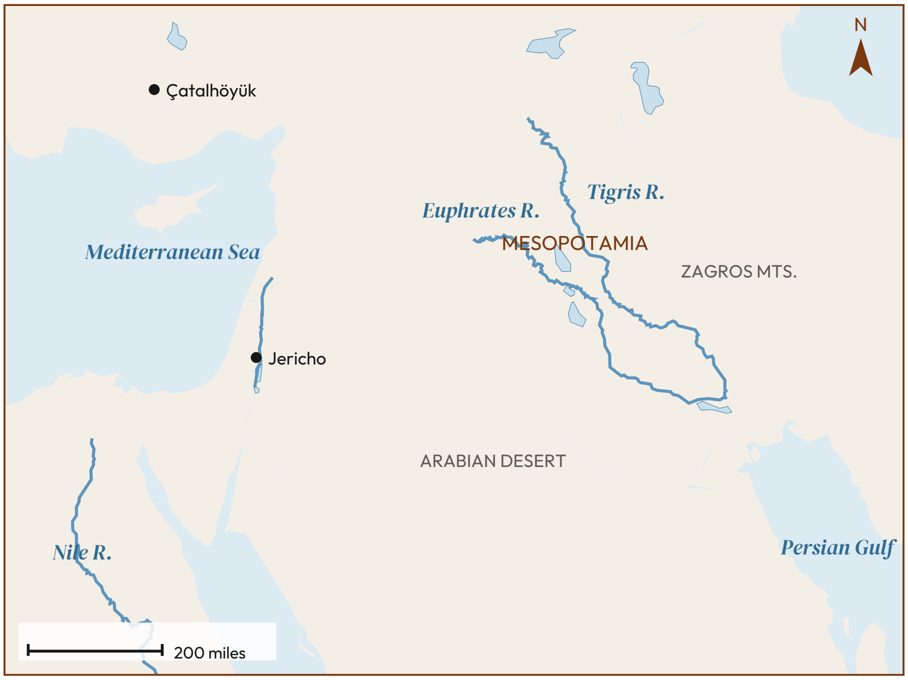
THINK ABOUT IT

Would you rather move every season to find food, or stay in one place and grow it? What would you gain and lose?

2 Learn

Beginning around 10,000 BCE in the Fertile Crescent of Southwest Asia, people began planting wild wheat and barley and herding goats and sheep. This change, called the Agricultural Revolution, took thousands of years. Farming also began on its own in other places: rice and millet in China, corn in Mexico, potatoes in South America.

Early farming villages in the Fertile Crescent


N
Çatalhöyük
Mediterranean Sea
Euphrates R.
Tigris R.
MESOPOTAMIA
ZAGROS MTS.
Jericho
ARABIAN DESERT
Nile R.
Persian Gulf
200 miles

Before farming	After farming
nomadic	settled villages
small bands	larger populations
food found or hunted	food grown and stored; surplus
few possessions	houses, pottery, tools for farming
most people did the same work	some people specialized in other jobs

Farming brought problems too. People worked long hours, ate fewer kinds of food, and could starve if crops failed. Living close together and near animals spread disease. Still, food surplus allowed populations to grow and set the stage for cities.

ACTIVITY · GAINS AND LOSSES

Was farming an improvement?

You need: paper.

1. Make a T-chart: Gains | Losses.
2. List at least four of each from the lesson.
3. Decide: for an ordinary person, was life better or worse? Write a claim with two pieces of evidence.

Record: your T-chart and claim.

KEY IDEA

Domesticating plants and animals let people settle, grow surpluses, and build larger communities, with new benefits and new problems.

3 Check Your Understanding

✎ CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Directions: Answer each question. Write your answers in Workbook Lesson 1.3, Part A. Then check with your teacher.

1. Where did farming first begin?
2. What is a surplus?
3. Name one problem farming created.

4 Wrap Up

✓ REMEMBER

Farming let people settle and grow surpluses, changing human life.

LESSON 1.4
Week 2 · Lesson 2 of 2

Unit 1: Early Humans and Mesopotamia

Lesson 1.4: From Villages to Civilizations

TODAY'S GOAL

I can identify the features of a civilization and explain how surplus led to cities.

Standards: C3 D2.His.1.6-8

TODAY'S ASSIGNMENT

- ☐ Read Lesson 1.4 in this book with your teacher.
- ☐ Do the Activity activity: Village to City Simulation.
- ☐ Answer the Check Your Understanding questions in Workbook Lesson 1.4, Part A.
- ☐ Complete the rest of Workbook Lesson 1.4 (Parts B–D).

WORDS TO KNOW

civilization	A complex society with cities, government, specialized jobs, social classes, and record keeping.
specialization	Doing one kind of job and trading for other needs.
social class	A group of people with similar wealth or status.

1 Get Ready

THINK ABOUT IT

What makes a city different from a village?

2 Learn

Some farming villages grew into towns. Jericho, near the Jordan River, had a stone wall and tower by about 8000 BCE. Çatalhöyük in Anatolia (modern Turkey) was home to thousands of people around 7000 BCE; its houses were built so close together that people walked across the rooftops and entered through openings in the roofs.

Historians use several features to describe a civilization:

Feature	Why it appears
cities	food surplus supports many people in one place
organized government	leaders manage water, defense, and laws
specialized jobs	potters, weavers, priests, soldiers, traders
social classes	some people gain more wealth or power
religion and public buildings	temples unite people around shared beliefs
writing and record keeping	track harvests, taxes, and trade
technology and art	new tools, buildings, and crafts

Farming → Food surplus → Population grows → Specialized jobs and trade → Cities and government

ACTIVITY · VILLAGE TO CITY SIMULATION

How does a surplus change a community?

You need: 20 dried beans (grain); role cards: farmer, potter, priest, guard, trader.

1 Each farmer 'grows' 5 beans per season but needs only 3 to eat.

2 Decide how the 2 extra beans per farmer can support people with other jobs.

3 Add one more job each round as the surplus grows.

Record: how many non-farmers your surplus could support, and the new problems (who decides? who guards the beans?).

KEY IDEA

Food surplus led to larger populations, specialized jobs, and the features of civilization.

3 Check Your Understanding

✎ CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Directions: Answer each question. Write your answers in Workbook Lesson 1.4, Part A. Then check with your teacher.

1. Name three features of a civilization.
2. What made specialization possible?
3. How did people enter houses at Çatalhöyük?

4 Wrap Up

✓ REMEMBER

Surplus → population → specialization → cities and government.

LESSON 1.5
Week 3 · Lesson 1 of 2
Unit 1: Early Humans and Mesopotamia

Lesson 1.5: Mesopotamia: The Land Between the Rivers

TODAY'S GOAL

I can explain how the geography of Mesopotamia shaped early civilization there.

Standards: C3 D2.Geo.2.6-8, D2.Geo.4.6-8

TODAY'S ASSIGNMENT

- ☐ Read Lesson 1.5 in this book with your teacher.
- ☐ Do the Activity activity: Irrigation Model.
- ☐ Answer the Check Your Understanding questions in Workbook Lesson 1.5, Part A.
- ☐ Complete the rest of Workbook Lesson 1.5 (Parts B–D).

WORDS TO KNOW

Mesopotamia	Greek for “land between the rivers”; the region between the Tigris and Euphrates.
irrigation	Bringing water to crops through canals or ditches.
silt	Fine, rich soil carried and left behind by rivers.
levee	A raised bank that keeps a river from flooding.

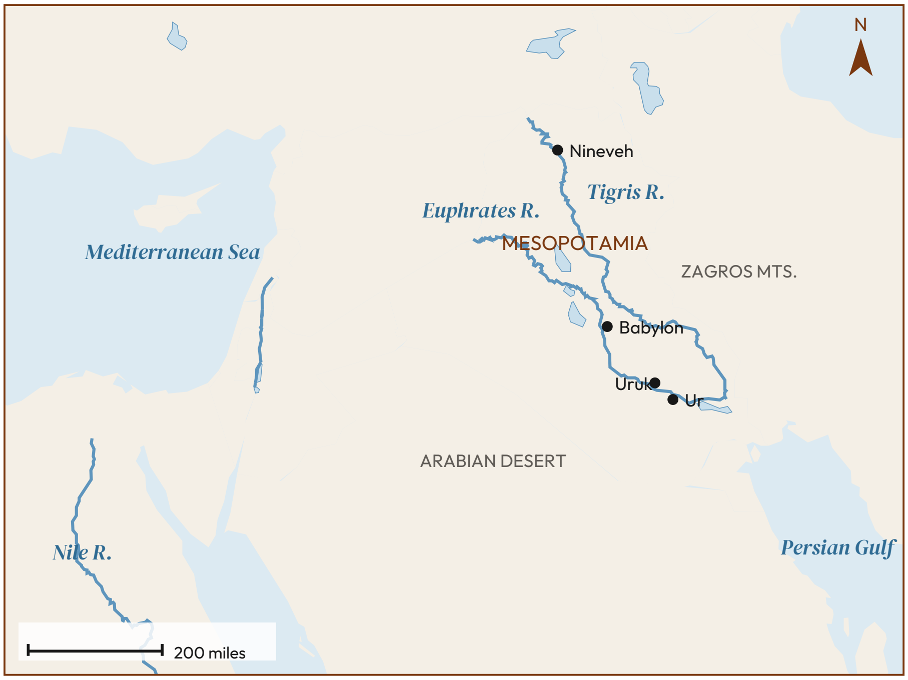
1 Get Ready

THINK ABOUT IT

Mesopotamia had hot, dry summers and almost no rain in the south, yet it became home to the world's first cities. How?

2 Learn

The Fertile Crescent


N
Nineveh
Tigris R.
Euphrates R.
MESOPOTAMIA
Mediterranean Sea
ZAGROS MTS.
Babylon
Uruk
Ur
ARABIAN DESERT
Nile R.
Persian Gulf
200 miles

Mesopotamia lies between the Tigris and Euphrates rivers in modern Iraq. Each spring, snow melting in the northern mountains made the rivers flood, spreading rich silt over the plain. But the floods were unpredictable: some years they were too small, other years they destroyed fields and villages. Summers were hot and rainfall was low.

Farmers solved these problems by working together. They dug irrigation canals to carry river water to fields, built levees to hold back floods, and stored water for dry months. Organizing these big projects required leaders and laws. The region had few trees and little stone, so people built with sun-dried mud bricks and traded grain and cloth for wood, stone, and metal.

Geographic challenge	Human solution
unpredictable floods	levees and drainage ditches
little rain in summer	irrigation canals and storage basins
few trees or stone	mud bricks; trade for resources
flat land, open to invaders	city walls and armies

ACTIVITY · IRRIGATION MODEL

How can canals bring water to fields?

You need: a baking pan with soil or sand; a cup of water; a craft stick.

1 Shape a “river” along one side of the pan.
2 Use the stick to carve canals from the river to three “fields.”
3 Pour water into the river at the high end. Where does it go?
4 Add a small dirt bank (levee) and test it again.

Record: a labeled sketch of your irrigation system and what worked.

KEY IDEA

Mesopotamia's rivers gave rich soil and water, but floods and dry summers forced people to cooperate on irrigation and levees.

3 Check Your Understanding

✎ CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Directions: Answer each question. Write your answers in Workbook Lesson 1.5, Part A. Then check with your teacher.

1. What does “Mesopotamia” mean?
2. Name the two rivers.
3. Why did Mesopotamians build with mud brick?

4 Wrap Up

✓ REMEMBER

Rivers gave Mesopotamia rich soil, but floods and drought required irrigation and cooperation.

LESSON 1.6
Week 3 · Lesson 2 of 2

Unit 1: Early Humans and Mesopotamia

Lesson 1.6: Sumer: City-States, Ziggurats, and Society

TODAY'S GOAL

I can describe Sumerian city-states, religion, and social classes.

Standards: C3 D2.His.1.6-8, D2.Civ.6.6-8

TODAY'S ASSIGNMENT

- ☐ Read Lesson 1.6 in this book with your teacher.
- ☐ Do the Activity activity: Design a Ziggurat.
- ☐ Answer the Check Your Understanding questions in Workbook Lesson 1.6, Part A.
- ☐ Complete the rest of Workbook Lesson 1.6 (Parts B–D).

WORDS TO KNOW

city-state	A city and the farmland around it with its own government.
ziggurat	A large stepped temple tower in a Sumerian city.
polytheism	Belief in many gods.
scribe	A person trained to read and write and keep records.

1 Get Ready

THINK ABOUT IT

If your town had its own king, army, and gods, how would you feel about the next town over?

2 Learn

By about 3500 BCE, the people of Sumer, in southern Mesopotamia, had built some of the world's first cities, including Ur and Uruk. Each was a city-state with its own ruler, army, and patron god. City-states often fought over water and land.

Sumerians practiced polytheism. They believed gods controlled nature and that people must serve them. At the center of each city stood a ziggurat, a huge stepped tower of mud brick with a temple on top. Priests were powerful, and at first they helped manage the city's grain. Over time, war leaders became kings, who claimed to rule with the gods' approval.

Social class	Who
upper class	kings, priests, and nobles
middle class	merchants, artisans, scribes, farmers who owned land
lower class	farm workers and laborers
enslaved people	often prisoners of war or people in debt

Women in Sumer could own property and run businesses, and some were priestesses, but most power belonged to men.

ACTIVITY · DESIGN A ZIGGURAT

What did a ziggurat show about Sumerian values?

You need: sugar cubes or building blocks; paper.

1 Build a three-level stepped tower with a shrine on top.

2 Add a ramp or stairway.

3 Write two sentences explaining why the temple was the tallest building in the city.

Record: a sketch and your explanation.

KEY IDEA

Sumer was made of independent city-states centered on ziggurats, ruled by kings and priests, with clear social classes.

3 Check Your Understanding

✎ CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Directions: Answer each question. Write your answers in Workbook Lesson 1.6, Part A. Then check with your teacher.

1. Name two Sumerian city-states.
2. What was a ziggurat?
3. Why did city-states fight?

4 Wrap Up

✓ REMEMBER

Sumer's city-states centered on ziggurats with kings, priests, and social classes.

LESSON 1.7
Week 4 · Lesson 1 of 2
Unit 1: Early Humans and Mesopotamia

Lesson 1.7: Cuneiform and the Invention of Writing

TODAY'S GOAL

I can explain how and why writing developed in Sumer and how it changed society.

Standards: C3 D2.His.1.6-8

WORDS TO KNOW

cuneiform	Sumerian writing made of wedge-shaped marks pressed into clay.
stylus	A pointed tool used to write on clay.
epic	A long poem about a hero's deeds.

TODAY'S ASSIGNMENT

- ☐ Read Lesson 1.7 in this book with your teacher.
- ☐ Do the Activity activity: Clay Tablet Scribe.
- ☐ Answer the Check Your Understanding questions in Workbook Lesson 1.7, Part A.
- ☐ Complete the rest of Workbook Lesson 1.7 (Parts B–D).

1 Get Ready

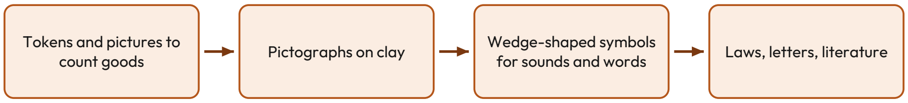
THINK ABOUT IT

How would your life change if nothing could be written down?

2 Learn

Around 3200 BCE, Sumerians in cities like Uruk began keeping records on clay tablets. At first they drew small pictures to count grain, sheep, and taxes. Over time the pictures became wedge-shaped marks pressed with a reed stylus: cuneiform, from the Latin word for “wedge.” Cuneiform was used for more than 3,000 years and for many languages.

Writing was hard to learn, so scribes trained for years in schools. They wrote contracts, laws, letters, medical texts, prayers, and literature, including the Epic of Gilgamesh, one of the oldest stories in the world. It tells of Gilgamesh, a king of Uruk, who searches for the secret of living forever and learns that every human life must end.


Tokens and pictures to count goods
Pictographs on clay
Wedge-shaped symbols for sounds and words
Laws, letters, literature

Other Sumerian innovations include the wheel (used for pottery and carts), the plow, sailboats, and a number system based on 60, which is why we still have 60 minutes in an hour and 360 degrees in a circle.

ACTIVITY · CLAY TABLET SCRIBE

What was it like to write in cuneiform?

You need: air-dry clay or play dough; a craft stick cut to a wedge point or a chopstick.

1. Flatten the clay into a tablet.
2. Press wedge shapes to record a “receipt”: 5 sheep and 3 jars of barley (invent symbols).
3. Trade tablets with a partner and try to read each other's record.

Record: your symbol key and two problems a scribe would face.

KEY IDEA

Writing began as record keeping, became cuneiform, and let people keep laws, history, and literature.

3 Check Your Understanding

✎ CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Directions: Answer each question. Write your answers in Workbook Lesson 1.7, Part A. Then check with your teacher.

1. What was cuneiform first used for?
2. What does cuneiform mean?
3. Who was Gilgamesh?

4 Wrap Up

✓ REMEMBER

Cuneiform began as record keeping and grew into laws and literature.

LESSON 1.8
Week 4 · Lesson 2 of 2
Unit 1: Early Humans and Mesopotamia

Lesson 1.8: Empires and the Code of Hammurabi

TODAY'S GOAL

I can describe the first empires and analyze Hammurabi's Code as a primary source.

Standards: C3 D2.Civ.3.6-8, D2.His.10.6-8

WORDS TO KNOW

empire
Many lands and peoples ruled by one government.

code of law
A written set of laws.

stele
A tall carved stone slab.

TODAY'S ASSIGNMENT

- ☐ Read Lesson 1.8 in this book with your teacher.
- ☐ Do the Activity activity: Fair or Unfair?.
- ☐ Answer the Check Your Understanding questions in Workbook Lesson 1.8, Part A.
- ☐ Complete the rest of Workbook Lesson 1.8 (Parts B–D).

1 Get Ready

THINK ABOUT IT

Why might it matter that laws are written down for everyone to see?

2 Learn

Around 2334 BCE, Sargon of Akkad conquered the Sumerian city-states and created what many historians call the world's first empire. Later, Hammurabi, king of Babylon (ruled about 1792–1750 BCE), united much of Mesopotamia. About 1754 BCE he had 282 laws carved on a tall stone stele for public display. The stele is now in the Louvre museum in Paris.

READING · PRIMARY SOURCE

From the Code of Hammurabi

Babylon, about 1754 BCE. Translated by L. W. King (1910). Public domain.

196. If a man put out the eye of another man, his eye shall be put out.

198. If he put out the eye of a freed man, or break the bone of a freed man, he shall pay one gold mina.

199. If he put out the eye of a man's slave, or break the bone of a man's slave, he shall pay one-half of its value.

229. If a builder build a house for some one, and does not construct it properly, and the house which he built fall in and kill its owner, then that builder shall be put to death.

LOOK CLOSER · ANALYZE A PRIMARY SOURCE

What do Laws 196, 198, and 199 reveal about Babylonian society?

1 Law 196: harming another man means the same harm in return (“an eye for an eye”).
2 Law 198: harming a freed man means paying a fine (one gold mina) instead.
3 Law 199: harming an enslaved person means paying the owner.

Answer: Punishments depended on social class, so Babylonian law treated people unequally; laws protected property and order more than equal rights.

Hammurabi's Code was not the first law code, but it is one of the best preserved. By writing laws in public, he showed that rules applied across his empire, and he claimed the gods gave him authority to rule justly.

ACTIVITY · FAIR OR UNFAIR?

Do these laws match our ideas of justice?

You need: the source excerpt; highlighters.

1. Highlight each punishment.
2. Rate each law from 1 (very unfair) to 5 (very fair) by today's standards.
3. Find one idea in the code that is similar to modern law (for example, builders responsible for safe buildings).

Record: your ratings and a paragraph comparing Hammurabi's Code with modern laws.

KEY IDEA

Sargon built the first empire; Hammurabi's written code brought order but punished people differently by class.

3 Check Your Understanding

✎ CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Directions: Answer each question. Write your answers in Workbook Lesson 1.8, Part A. Then check with your teacher.

1. Who created the first empire?
2. About when was Hammurabi's Code written?
3. Did the code treat all people equally?

4 Wrap Up

✓ REMEMBER

Sargon built the first empire; Hammurabi wrote laws for all to see.

UNIT 1 REVIEW

Unit 1 Study Guide

Use this page to get ready for the unit test. Read each big idea, then try the review pages in your workbook.

Lesson	Remember...
1.1	Historians use primary and secondary sources; BCE counts down, CE counts up.
1.2	Early humans were nomadic hunter-gatherers who spread out of Africa.
1.3	Farming let people settle and grow surpluses, changing human life.
1.4	Surplus → population → specialization → cities and government.
1.5	Rivers gave Mesopotamia rich soil, but floods and drought required irrigation and cooperation.
1.6	Sumer's city-states centered on ziggurats with kings, priests, and social classes.
1.7	Cuneiform began as record keeping and grew into laws and literature.
1.8	Sargon built the first empire; Hammurabi wrote laws for all to see.

Glossary

Agricultural Revolution	The shift to farming.
archaeologist	A scientist who studies the past by digging up and examining artifacts and remains.
artifact	An object made or used by people in the past.
BCE / CE	“Before the Common Era” and “Common Era”: the years before and after year 1.
city-state	A city and the farmland around it with its own government.
civilization	A complex society with cities and government.
code of law	A written set of laws.
cuneiform	Sumerian wedge-shaped writing.
domestication	Taming plants and animals so they can be raised by people.
empire	Many lands under one ruler.
epic	A long poem about a hero's deeds.
hunter-gatherer	A person who gets food by hunting animals and gathering wild plants.
irrigation	Bringing water to crops.
levee	A raised bank that keeps a river from flooding.
Mesopotamia	Greek for “land between the rivers”; the region between the Tigris and Euphrates.
migration	Movement of people from one place to another.
Neolithic	The New Stone Age, when farming began.
nomad	A person who moves from place to place instead of living in one settlement.
Paleolithic	The Old Stone Age, when people made stone tools and lived as hunter-gatherers.
polytheism	Belief in many gods.
primary source	Created at the time by a participant.
scribe	A person trained to read and write and keep records.
secondary source	A source created later by someone studying the past.
silt	Fine, rich soil carried and left behind by rivers.
social class	A group of people with similar wealth or status.
specialization	Doing one kind of job and trading for other needs.

stele	A tall carved stone slab.
stylus	A pointed tool used to write on clay.
surplus	More than is needed to survive.
ziggurat	A large stepped temple tower in a Sumerian city.

Grade 7 Social Studies

Student Textbook

A full year of Grade 7 social studies. Students read maps, weigh primary and secondary sources, build timelines, and connect geography, history, government, and economics to the people and places that shaped our world.

This Student Textbook teaches every lesson: the big idea, key vocabulary, models and examples, and a short set of practice problems to check understanding. It pairs with the Student Workbook and the Teacher Edition.

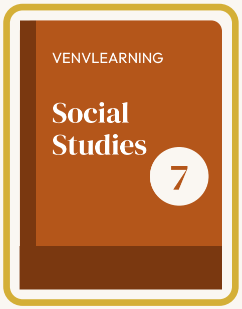
INSIDE THIS YEAR

01 Early Humans and Mesopotamia

IN THIS BOOK

- Clear lesson goals: “I can...” statements
- Key vocabulary with student-friendly definitions
- Models, examples, and Key Idea summaries
- A study guide and glossary for every unit

THE COMPLETE SET



Textbook

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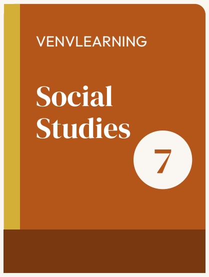
Workbook



Teacher Edition

Each lesson has the same number in all three books, so the textbook, workbook, and teacher pages always match.